status quo merely because of his friendship with GMD leader Jiang Jieshi. His diagnosis of the GMD's failure echoed that of Acheson, and at least the overall prescription seemed to match as well: "We have to take facts as they are."[32]

The Indian prime minister believed Delhi had to deal with the government in Beijing that existed, not the one it wished existed. In addition, if the Indian government "stood up for the bankrupt government in China now … this would give a fillip to communism in India."[33] He also believed that rather than isolating communist China, it was important to integrate and bind it with the international community.

Nehru's view of China flowed to a degree from mirror imaging, which would continue to affect his perception of China over the next half-decade. He and officials like Bajpai believed nationalism was the key driving force in China, as it was for India.[34] Nehru asserted that, much like his own government, a communist Chinese government would focus on internal issues—and it would do so in a pragmatic, rather than an ideological, way. Therefore, it would seek peace in its periphery. The Indian premier would consistently underestimate the effect of ideology on Chinese policymakers, despite the contention of Kavalam Madhava (K. M.) Panikkar, India's representative in China, that the Chinese Communist Party leadership was "fanatically imbued with a sense of mission to refashion society."[35]

India's limited defense capabilities also shaped the prime minister's view of China and policy options toward it. Nehru did not appear open to contemplating contingencies like a military threat to India if China took over Tibet because it would "affect the balance we are trying to create in India." That balance was in terms of both the defense-development balance and the civil-military balance.[36]

While Nehru was uncertain about China's external intentions, he was certain that India could not afford to provoke its northern neighbor. Thus it was the premier's view that "our general attitude to the new China should be a friendly expectation and waiting to see what happens."[37] Nehru's concern about provoking Beijing showed in his furious reaction to an article that led to Chinese communist press criticism of Indian interest in Tibet.[38] It was also evident in his negative reaction to discussions about a US-sponsored Pacific Pact, which envisioned including India, to counter China's potential "loss."